

Same-sex intimacy, also known as same-gender intimacy, refers to a close emotional, physical, sensual, or sexual relationship between people of the same sex or gender.^[1] While often associated with romantic and sexual relationships, intimacy also encompasses strong non-sexual and non-romantic relationships.

In History

Many historical figures are believed to have had intimate same-sex relationships. This includes but is not limited to Alexander the Great, Oscar Wilde, and Emily Dickinson, all of whom are documented to have had intimate same-sex relationships.

The topic of Alexander the Great's sexuality has been highly debated, particularly surrounding his relationship with his close friend, general, and confidant Hephaestion. Their friendship began when they were children studying under Aristotle and continued throughout their lives until Hephaestion's death. Aristotle described Alexander and Hephaestion as "one soul abiding in two bodies."^[2] Scholar William Woodthorpe wrote in his work *Alexander the Great: Sources and studies* that "There is then not one scrap of evidence for calling Alexander homosexual."^[3] Another scholar Athena Richardson argues that not only does the historical record support the assertion that Alexander may have been bisexual, but also that "Ancient biographers may have conducted censorship to conceal any implication of femininity or submissiveness in Alexander that this relationship dynamic might suggest. As a result, subsequent cultures would have hidden the relationship too."^[4] Regardless of the sexuality of Alexander or Hephaestion, the historical record clearly shows their relationship to be emotionally and physically intimate.

The poet Emily Dickinson has been well documented to have expressed desires for same-sex intimacy through her letters to her Susan Gilbert, which were revealed by a 1998 study to have been deliberately

censored to remove Gilbert's name.^[5] In these letters, Dickinson expresses feelings of immense desire for Gilbert, stating in one of them, "I hope for you so much and feel so eager for you, feel that I cannot wait, feel that now I must have you—that the expectation once more to see your face again, makes me feel hot and feverish, and my heart beats so fast."^[6]

Oscar Wilde had heavily documented same-sex romantic and sexual relationships, mostly through the extensive legal documentation from the multiple trials accusing him of the crime of sodomy.^[7] According to biographer Richard Ellmann's account, Wilde met a young man named Robert Ross at Oxford who was "so young and yet so knowing, was determined to seduce Wilde."^[8] The evidence produced in these trials documented in detail the same-sex intimate relationships Wilde had. The first trial, *Wilde v Queensbury*, resulted from the Marquess of Queensberry leaving a note at a club Wilde frequented publicly calling him a sodomite, resulting in Wilde accusing Queensberry of libel. The trial revealed that Wilde had been giving gifts to men and boys as young as 16 and the prosecution had allegedly located several male prostitutes willing to testify they had sex with Wilde.^[9] At the advice of his legal counsel, he dropped the case and declared bankruptcy.^[10] The second trial, *Regina v Wilde*, immediately followed the first trial. Wilde was formally arrested and charged with sodomy, found guilty, and served just under 2 years in jail.^[7]

1. <https://umatter.princeton.edu/respect/relationships/intimacy>
2. Diogenes Laërtius 5.1.20
3. Tarn, William Woodthorpe (1948), *Alexander the Great: Sources and studies*. p. 323
4. <https://scholarspace.library.gwu.edu/downloads/g732d9242?disposition=inline&locale=en>
5. Dobrow, Julie (November 8, 2018). ["How much editing was done to Emily Dickinson's poems after she died?"](#). Lit Hub. Archived from [the original](#) on August 25, 2019. Retrieved November 14, 2025.
6. Hart, Ellen Louise; Smith, Martha Nell, eds. (1998). *Open me carefully: Emily Dickinson's intimate letters to Susan Huntington Dickinson*. p. 35-37
7. Field, Marcus (4 October 2014). ["Is Oscar Wilde's reputation due for another reassessment?"](#). [The Independent](#). [Archived](#) from the original on 2 March 2021. Retrieved 14 November, 2025.
8. [Ellmann, Richard](#) (1988). [Oscar Wilde](#). New York: [Alfred A. Knopf](#). [ISBN](#) p. 275
9. Foldy, Michael S. (1997). *The Trials of Oscar Wilde: Deviance, Morality and Late-Victorian Society*. [Yale University Press](#). [ISBN](#) p. 17-19
10. Foldy, Michael S. (1997). *The Trials of Oscar Wilde: Deviance, Morality and Late-Victorian Society*. [Yale University Press](#). [ISBN](#) p. 150.